

Clarifying the role of authenticity in online self-effects: examining authentic cognition and authentic self-expression

Zijian Lew^{*,} , Jaz Low, Yingzhi Mar

Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information, Nanyang Technological University, Singapore, Singapore

*Corresponding author: Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information, Nanyang Technological University, 31 Nanyang Link, Singapore 637718, Singapore. Email: zlew@ntu.edu.sg.

Abstract

Research on self-effects (i.e., how communicators influence themselves) has shown that people can change their self-perceptions, cognitions, attitudes, and behaviors according to their public online self-presentations. Identity shift theorizing has argued that self-presentations have to be authentic to elicit the greatest self-effects. The present study posited that authentic self-presentations should be conceptualized as two different components—authentic cognition and authentic self-expression—understood from a communicator's point of view. In a between-subjects experiment, participants were instructed to publicly self-present on their actual social media accounts in one of three ways that correspond to descending levels of authentic cognition and authentic self-expression: with mindfulness (with awareness, balance, and acceptance), with facticity (being purely factual and unemotional), or with self-glorification (with exaggerations and embellishments). Results showed that participants who self-presented mindfully experienced less toxic positivity than those who self-glorified, and less toxic positivity was associated with greater commitment to their self-presentations and greater recalled enjoyment. However, the more narcissistic participants were, the more they enjoyed self-glorification than self-presenting mindfully. Therefore, the study showed that authenticity shaped self-effects associated with public online self-presentation and extended self-effects theorizing to cognitive-affective evaluations of recalled experience.

Lay Summary

This study examined how crafting social media posts influences the communicators themselves. Participants were told to post about a recent learning experience where they witnessed significant personal growth through a challenging time. Naturally, some people would be more authentic in their sharing, and others less. But how might different communicators, who write with different degrees of authenticity, influence themselves differently in terms of (a) their willingness to commit to how they portrayed themselves, (b) their recalled enjoyment of the experience, and (c) their feeling of toxic positivity? Some participants were induced to be highly authentic by being mindful: writing in a balanced manner and from a place of non-judgment. Other participants were induced to have medium authenticity by being factual: unemotionally describing their experiences. The remaining participants were induced to have low authenticity by self-glorifying: exaggerating their own qualities and adding embellishments. Although it may seem intuitively appealing to self-glorify on social media, participants who self-glorified reported greater toxic positivity, less enjoyment, and lower commitment than those who were mindful (although narcissistic individuals did not mind self-glorifying). Those who self-glorified also reported lower commitment than those who were factual. Thus, being inauthentic by self-glorifying can be costly for communicators.

Although communication research has traditionally studied the influence of messages on audiences, the popularization of social media has enabled ordinary individuals to send messages to a mass audience, giving rise to research on self-effects—how communicators “involuntarily influence their own cognitions, emotions, attitudes, or behavior” (Valkenburg,

2017, p. 478). The malleability of online self-presentations allows greater selective self-presentation than when face-to-face, widening the possibilities for self-effects (Walther, 2007). Among various theories and perspectives, two complementary lines of research inform self-effects: identity shift and expressive writing.

Associate Editor: Caleb Carr

Received: August 30, 2025. Revised: August 11, 2026. Accepted: August 20, 2026

© The Author(s) 2026. Published by Oxford University Press on behalf of the International Communication Association.

This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>), which permits unrestricted reuse, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited.

Identity shift (Carr et al., 2021; Gonzales & Hancock, 2008) focuses on self-effects in online environments, including but not limited to its consideration of computer-generated feedback (Walther et al., 2011) and its attention to persistent and ephemeral messages (Choi et al., 2026). The key principle driving identity shift is public commitment: People who self-present publicly online expect that others have witnessed their public self-presentations, and therefore commit to maintaining a consistent image (see Schlenker, 1986). Thus, communicators' behaviors influence their own self-concepts, providing an alternative to the notion that people's self-concepts drive their behaviors.

Separately, expressive writing is typically researched in non-digital and non-public environments, focusing on how writing one's thoughts and feelings can influence a writer's memory of and emotional response toward past experiences (Pennebaker & Chung, 2011). Its relevance to the present study lies in its reasoning that the process of writing allows people to reorganize, reframe, and/or relabel their past experiences, thus changing how they think or feel about those experiences (Baikie & Wilhelm, 2005).

Despite the differences between these two lines of research, it is possible to find areas of complementarity. If people write about their personal experiences in public, can the writing process influence their cognitive/affective evaluation of that experience and engender some public commitment, such that people are beholden to their "new" cognitions? Put differently, self-effects research can borrow from identity shift to consider commitment and authenticity, and from expressive writing to consider cognitive-affective outcomes.

To this end, one of the dependent variables tested in this research is people's recalled *enjoyment* of an experience. Enjoyment is important for several reasons. First, narrating an experience can change how positively or negatively people remember the experience (Marsh & Tversky, 2004). For example, writing about negative experiences can lead people to reframe them into partially positive experiences. Second, enjoyment is a construct that allows an overall assessment of past experiences in a valenced manner—and communicators' enjoyment may be influenced by the process of creating/sending a message (Diehl et al., 2016; Lew & Flanagan, 2024). In short, when people share their experiences online, can the cognitive processes by which they craft messages influence their recalled enjoyment of those experiences?

Another dependent variable we used was *commitment*. According to identity shift theory, people internalize their self-presentations due to public commitment—they want to maintain a consistent image to others, which may include audiences in general, close ties, or even imagined audiences (Carr et al., 2021). In several identity shift experiments, commitment was inferred: Some participants self-presented in public while others self-presented in private, but only the former group internalized their self-presentations, and thus participants in it were surmised to have done so due to public commitment (e.g., Gonzales & Hancock, 2008; Walther et al., 2011). Hence, publicness is one important way by which people become committed to what they say online. In this study, we measured commitment instead of making an inference about it.

The present study also tested the role of authenticity in self-effects. Carr et al. (2021) argued that for identity shift to occur,

"self-presentations must be salient and authentic" and that "participants must draw from personal experiences to experience self-transformation" (p. 205). The assertion that "participants must draw from personal experiences" seems to imply that authenticity has a cognitive aspect, alongside a self-expressive aspect (see Kreling et al., 2022). Clarifying this cognitive/self-expressive duality of authenticity and testing Carr et al.'s (2021) claims regarding authenticity should help advance identity shift theory and, more broadly, self-effects research.

In the context of identity shift, authentic self-expression is not difficult to accept: Communicators are more likely to experience identity shift if their messages were sincere than if their messages were fictitious. As such, the present research aims to show the relevance of authentic cognition—a combination of the awareness of one's own cognitions and the unbiased processing of self-relevant information, as defined within Kernis and Goldman's (2006) framework—to identity shift and self-effects. Self-effects can be engendered not just by the act of message release but also by the cognitions that are associated with the expectation of expression or the process of composing a message (Pingree, 2007).¹ If we apply this reasoning to authenticity, then the authenticity of communicators' cognitions is just as important to self-effects as the authenticity of their expressions.

This article therefore presents an experiment about how (in) authentic self-presentations can influence two aspects of self-effects that potentially co-occur: enjoyment and commitment. The independent variable, self-presentation type, had three levels of motivations, ordered from most to least authentic: mindfulness, facticity, and self-glorification. We tested the idea that cognitive processes linked to more authentic self-presentation motivations may be associated with greater enjoyment and/or greater commitment, the latter of which is a mechanism by which identity shift occurs (Carr et al., 2021). The experiment instructed participants to write, with different motivations corresponding to varying levels of authenticity, about a recent learning experience that led to personal growth through a challenging time. Participants then publicly posted what they wrote on their own LinkedIn accounts. Thus, the study clarifies the role of authenticity in self-effects and expands the scope of self-effects research to include cognitive-affective variables such as recalled enjoyment of past experiences.

Authenticity and its different conceptualizations

Over the years, there have been many different conceptualizations of authenticity. In communication, particularly where message effects on audiences are concerned, authenticity tends to be something that audiences attribute to a message or its sender. But insofar as self-effects are concerned, authenticity can also be understood as a perception by communicators regarding their own cognitions and expressions. Here, we first present an overview of these different perspectives before focusing on authenticity as it pertains to self-effects.

One popular conceptualization of authenticity in online environments was proposed by Lee (2020), who argued audiences perceive three facets of authenticity: source authenticity, message authenticity, and interaction authenticity. Source

authenticity is the extent to which audiences perceive communicators to be who they claim to be, message authenticity is the perceived veracity of a message's claims and the perceived transparency of its purpose, and interaction authenticity is audiences' perceptions of the degree to which they are in an actual interaction (Lee, 2020). Salisbury and Pooley (2017) discussed authenticity markers on social media, such as perceived consistency, perceived spontaneity, and self-disclosure. The more audiences perceive that a communicator is consistent over time, is spontaneous, or makes appropriate self-disclosures, the more audiences rate the communicator as authentic (Salisbury & Pooley, 2017). As a whole, these perspectives center on how audiences utilize various authenticity markers to assess the authenticity of a communicator, message, or interaction (Lee, 2020). Authenticity, in such instances, is not necessarily something that a message or communicator possesses, but is constituted in audiences' perceptions.

However, beyond audience-side perceptions, authenticity can also be applicable to communicator-side dynamics. In the present context of self-effects, Kernis and Goldman's (2006) conceptualization of authenticity is especially applicable to the cognitive processes that communicators go through when they (a) create messages and (b) send messages. Kernis and Goldman (2006) theorized that authenticity has four aspects: awareness, unbiased processing, behavior, and relational orientation. The first two aspects—*awareness* and *unbiased processing*—pertain to people's cognitions in terms of being true to themselves and the latter two aspects—*behavior* and *relational orientation*—pertain to people's self-expressions in terms of being true to others. Referencing Kernis and Goldman (2006), awareness refers to knowing one's cognitions (e.g., motives, feelings) and traits; unbiased processing "involves objectivity with respect to one's positive and negative self-aspects, emotions, and other internal experiences, information, and private knowledge" (p. 296); behavior refers to "acting in ways congruent with one's values, preferences, and needs... rather than acting merely to please others or to attain rewards or avoid punishments" (p. 302); and relational orientation is about being genuine and sincere in one's close relationships.

The utility of Kernis and Goldman's (2006) conceptualization of authenticity vis-à-vis self-effects is that awareness and unbiased processing are relevant to the message creation process, while behavior and relational orientation are relevant to the psychological and social dynamics when a message is sent. Thus, Kernis and Goldman's (2006) conceptualization of authenticity covers self-effects due to the writing process and self-effects due to message release. Notably, self-effects comprise more than what comes after a message is sent. As expressive writing research has shown, self-effects can occur when communicators cognitively reorganize or reframe their past experiences as part of the writing process (Pennebaker & Chung, 2011; Valkenburg, 2017). Put simply, the process of writing messages has an important influence on self-effects.

In more specific terms, if communicators maintain an *awareness* of their thoughts and feelings when they write messages, and if they process these thoughts and feelings in an *unbiased* way (i.e., with as much objectivity as possible and with minimal distortion or exaggeration), they can be said to be acting authentically in a *cognitive* way. Of course, two caveats apply: (i)

complete authenticity is impossible (just as being completely aware and completely unbiased is impossible) and (ii) authenticity in this form can only be assessed by the communicators themselves (it would be difficult for audiences to reliably assess a communicator's awareness or unbiased processing). Subsequently, if communicators *behave* congruently with their thoughts/feelings and have a truthful, sincere *relational orientation* toward others in their messages, then they can be said to be acting authentically in a *self-expressive* way.

These two aspects of authenticity—an inward, cognitive aspect and an outward, expressive aspect—are recognized in the literature, albeit sometimes under different terminology. For example, Kreling et al. (2022) argued that authenticity is made up of (i) authentic awareness and (ii) authentic self-expression: "The former refers to exploring and knowing one's identity. The latter is [about] presenting oneself in a way that is consistent with how one knows the self" (p. 2). Additionally, Medlock (2012) argued that authenticity involves (i) an individual's cognitions toward themselves that are "grounded in here-and-now awareness of the inner flow of experience" (Medlock, 2012, p. 43), as well as (ii) the sincere expression of those cognitions toward others, among other things. And according to Erickson (1995), authenticity is a commitment to self-values (i.e., values that people desire for and expect of themselves), as they negotiate their different context-dependent role identities. In contrast, Erickson argued that being true to others is sincerity, that is, "a congruence between one's outward appearance and the underlying reality of self" (Erickson, 1995, p. 123). Thus, authenticity is self-referential and sincerity is other-referential to Erickson (1995). Across these examples, despite slight disagreements in terms of nomenclature, we can observe that authenticity has at least two aspects that are useful for understanding self-effects: being true to oneself (when communicators compose their messages) and being true to others (when communicators release their messages).

Going back to Kernis and Goldman's (2006) conceptualization of authenticity, we therefore collectively label the awareness and unbiased processing dimensions of authenticity as *authentic cognition*, and the behavior and relational orientation dimensions of authenticity as *authentic self-expression*. The label of authentic self-expression follows Kreling et al. (2022), but we replaced their term authentic awareness with authentic cognition to better capture its correspondence to both awareness and unbiased processing in Kernis and Goldman's (2006) conceptualization. In this way, whereas authentic cognition is intrapersonal (being true to oneself), authentic self-expression is interpersonal (being true to others). We argue that together they capture the two major aspects of authenticity in self-effects that pertain to message creation and message release, from a communicator's point of view.

The role of authenticity in self-effects

Identity shift theory posited that the authenticity of self-presentations is important for eliciting self-effects, in that communicators should "draw from personal experiences" (Carr et al., 2021, p. 205). This process typically involved

narrating a recalled experience via a self-presentation. For example, participants in two separate studies were tasked to self-present either as introverts or extroverts, via text (Gonzales & Hancock, 2008) or in immersive virtual reality (Peña & Hill, 2020). The expressed trait (i.e., introversion/extroversion) was randomly assigned and the experimental induction instructed participants to “think of experiences in both their past and present that were consistent with the assigned trait and to rely on those examples when answering questions” related to “pastimes with friends, family vacations, current extracurricular activities, and the most important thing learned in college” (Gonzales & Hancock, 2008, p. 173). Peña and Hill (2020) utilized the same instructions and provided to their participants some typical behaviors of introverted and extroverted people. This method has also been extended to other contexts, such as brand attitudes. In Carr and Hayes (2019), the self-presentation manipulation was for participants to answer four questions in a way that showed they either strongly or weakly identified with the Starbucks brand. Participants were “directed not to lie, but rather draw from their own prior experiences and knowledge to answer questions” (Carr & Hayes, 2019, p. 427).

Given the foregoing, the value that authentic cognition and authentic self-expression bring to self-effects² is the clear demarcation of cognitive and expressive elements in the process of self-presenting as communicators draw from personal experiences. That is, drawing from personal experiences has at least two aspects: (i) authentic cognition (i.e., thinking about personal experiences with a high level of awareness and objectivity in relation to what one thought or felt) and (ii) authentic self-expression (i.e., narrating personal experiences to others with sincerity and honesty). If these conditions are met, and when communicators self-present in public, identity shift theory predicts that the communicators will experience commitment.

Commitment

Identity shift theory (Carr et al., 2021) claims that people’s self-concepts can change in alignment with their public self-presentations. A key mechanism that drives this change is commitment, in that public behavior contributes toward people’s reputations and thus motivates people to behave similarly in the future (Schlenker, 1986). As such, “individuals become committed to self-presentations they make publicly” (Gonzales & Hancock, 2008, p. 168). Across numerous contexts, including the self-presentation of personality traits such as introversion/extroversion (Gonzales & Hancock, 2008), aesthetic tastes (Johnson & Van Der Heide, 2015), brand attitudes (Carr & Hayes, 2019), and even political opinions (Winter et al., 2022), communicators have demonstrated commitment to their public (vs. private) self-presentations. Notably, studies have also examined identity shift using longitudinal methods (e.g., Johnson & Van Der Heide, 2015; Lane et al., 2025), demonstrating that public commitment to self-presentations can produce shifts in self-concepts over time.

However, the publicness of the self-presentations may not be the only factor that influences commitment. Considering the requirement that communicators draw from their personal experiences, commitment may therefore also be influenced by the extent to which communicators perceive their own

self-presentations as authentic. Following Carr et al.’s (2021) assertion that authenticity is necessary for self-effects, we argue that if communicators wrote with authentic cognition during the writing process, and if their messages contained elements of authentic self-expression, then they should experience a high level of commitment. This could happen because authentic cognition and authentic self-expression likely reflect a communicator’s “true self,” so the content written by the communicator is highly self-relevant (Vansteenkiste et al., 2018). Such self-relevant content may become further integrated into the self as an expression of the communicator’s identity, fostering commitment.

Authenticity can be associated with various motivations for sharing on social media. For example, whereas people motivated to engage in capitalization should share good things about themselves with some authenticity (Langston, 1994), people motivated to self-promote should share good things about themselves with relatively less authenticity because it involves bragging (Kim & McDonald-Liu, 2023). Among various possible self-presentation motivations, *mindfulness*, *facticity*, and *self-glorification* correspond to varying levels of authentic cognition and authentic self-expression. As such, the present research focused on these motivations for their theoretical relevance.

Self-presenting with mindfulness corresponds to high authentic cognition and high authentic self-expression. Mindfulness is defined as being aware of past and present experiences while maintaining a balanced, non-judgmental, and accepting attitude toward those experiences (Brown et al., 2007). Mindfulness has been found to be correlated to all four of Kernis and Goldman’s (2006) subdimensions of authenticity (Allan et al., 2015). The correlation between mindfulness and authenticity has also been established in samples from the UK and China, demonstrating some cross-cultural robustness (Chen & Murphy, 2019). Being mindful meets the criteria for authentic cognition because communicators are aware of their own thoughts/feelings and process those thoughts/feelings in an unbiased manner (i.e., with acceptance and not distorted by desires). Being mindful also meets the criteria for authentic self-expression because communicators, having acknowledged these cognitions, should behave and relate to others in accordance with these cognitions (see Ryan & Ryan, 2019). Therefore, mindful³ self-presentations should induce a high level of authenticity among communicators.

The second motivation in our study was facticity: to be factual and unemotional. Self-presenting with facticity corresponds to low authentic cognition and moderate authentic self-expression. Facticity should result in low authentic cognition because authentic cognition requires acknowledging one’s emotions (Kernis & Goldman, 2006) and being “aware of [one’s] inner states and [being] able to express them in behavior and emotion accordingly” (Kreling et al., 2022, p. 2). Being factual and unemotional may even involve the suppression of emotions and definitely does not meet the bar for authentic cognition. Furthermore, facticity should result in moderate authentic self-expression. On one hand, communicators are telling the truth by being wholly factual. But on the other hand, authentic self-expression is more than not lying; it requires communicators to reveal who they are in an open and genuine way (Kernis & Goldman, 2006). Thus, self-presenting with facticity should induce a moderate level of authenticity among communicators.

The third motivation in our study was self-glorification: to exaggerate one's own qualities, add embellishments, and make oneself seem impressive. Self-presenting with self-glorification corresponds to low authentic cognition and low authentic self-expression. Self-glorification is low on authentic cognition because there is a lack of unbiased processing. It requires people to knowingly think about themselves in a way that is self-enhancing within the bounds of believability, which may be discrepant from how they actually perceive themselves. In fact, processing is motivated and exaggerated. Self-glorification is also low on authentic self-expression because communicators promote themselves and are not relationally genuine with others. Thus, self-glorification should induce a low level of authenticity among communicators.

In the present research, one focus was on how different motivations linked to authentic cognition and authentic self-expression could influence commitment, above and beyond the effects of publicness. Across all our conditions, participants self-presented publicly, allowing for some minimal level of commitment due to publicness that may be magnified or undermined by variations in participants' authentic cognition or authentic self-expression. As such, making self-presentations with mindfulness should produce greater self-effects than self-presentations with self-glorification or facticity.⁴

H1: People who self-present with mindfulness have greater commitment to their self-presentations than people who self-present with (a) self-glorification or (b) facticity.

Enjoyment

The act of writing involves the reconstruction of thoughts, because words do not exist verbatim in people's heads (Pingree, 2007). Hence, each time communicators write about their personal experiences, these experiences are also reconstructed. In expressive writing, the process of writing can help people cognitively reconstruct or reframe personal experiences, particularly in relation to difficult experiences (Pennebaker & Chung, 2011) but also in relation to positive experiences (Wing et al., 2006).

After the expressive writing process, people experience positive cognitive-affective outcomes such as increased well-being in the long term or better mood in the short term (Baikie & Wilhelm, 2005). Scholars theorize that these benefits occur because the process of reconstructing or reframing past experiences allows communicators to, among other things, feel disinhibited, acknowledge their own emotions (e.g., by labeling emotions), and promote greater self-understanding (Pennebaker & Chung, 2011; Travagin et al., 2015).

Expressive writing therefore allows people to experience positive cognitive and affective outcomes. However, these benefits should accrue only to the extent that communicators get in touch with their deepest thoughts/feelings (therefore demonstrating awareness; Kernis & Goldman, 2006) and to do so without cognitive biases such as ego-defensiveness, self-esteem maintenance, self-enhancement, and the like (therefore demonstrating unbiased processing; Kernis and Goldman, 2006).

In other words, some degree of mindfulness is necessary before communicators can benefit cognitively/affectively from expressive writing or indeed any writing that requires them to reconstruct or reframe past experiences. In contrast, self-presenting with facticity requires communicators to only recollect the facts pertaining to what happened and self-glorification requires communicators to make themselves appear impressive. The motivations of facticity and self-glorification are thus unlikely to yield the cognitive and affective benefits described earlier. As such, we predict that:

H2: People who self-present with mindfulness perceive greater enjoyment of the experience than people who self-present with (a) self-glorification or (b) facticity.

Toxic positivity: a cost of self-glorification

Our arguments have thus far taken the view that self-presenting with mindfulness leads to more favorable self-effects than self-presenting with facticity or with self-glorification, because of the greater authenticity associated with mindfulness. This reasoning, however, runs counter to traditional theorizing on self-presentation. It is widely accepted that people are motivated to bridge the discrepancy between their perceived actual selves and their ideal or ought selves, in terms of how they are viewed by others (Higgins, 1987). On social media, communicators' motivation to bridge the aforementioned discrepancy is potentially even stronger, given that social media affords them the ability to selectively self-present to a greater extent than in face-to-face situations (Walther, 2007).

From this perspective, self-glorification (within believable limits) should be more rewarding for communicators than self-presenting with mindfulness, at least on the surface. This is because self-glorification (exaggerating one's qualities, adding embellishments, and making oneself seem impressive) has the potential to bridge the discrepancy between one's perceived actual self and one's ideal/ought self, but mindfulness (being balanced, nonjudgmental, and accepting) does not seem to bridge any discrepancy.

However, we argue that self-glorification has a "hidden" cost due to its inauthenticity. If the success of social exchanges were conceived as a function of rewards less cost (Thibaut & Kelley, 1959), then rewards can be understood as the extent to which a communicator's desired identity claim is believed by the audience (Schlenker, 2012) and costs can be understood as the cognitive effort expended to create the message. Therefore, even if self-glorification engenders rewards in that audiences believe a communicator's aggrandized self-claims, there is a cost⁵ for communicators due to the low level of authentic cognition involved in creating a self-glorification message.

To understand this cost, recall that authentic cognition is comprised of what Kernis and Goldman (2006) called awareness (knowing one's cognitions, traits, desires, emotions, etc.) and unbiased processing (being as objective as possible, or having as little denial/distortion as possible, in relation to one's experiences, self-knowledge, strengths and weaknesses, etc.). As previously

mentioned, self-glorification is low on authentic cognition because it lacks unbiased processing, since the whole point of self-glorification is to be biased in how one thinks of oneself. On this basis, we propose a hitherto unexplored mechanism (although certainly not the only mechanism) that pertains to the cost of self-glorification as a result of the inauthentic cognition associated with it: *toxic positivity* (see Figure 1).

We expect that toxic positivity explains the difference between mindful self-presentations and self-glorifying self-presentations. According to Salopek and Eastin (2024), toxic positivity occurs when communicators engage in “positive communication avoiding negative emotions or experiences” (p. 1). There is a positivity bias online (Waterloo et al., 2018), as people buy into the notion that they should be inspirational to others or show others they are happy or successful, among other things (Salopek & Eastin, 2024). For example, the social media site LinkedIn has been criticized for encouraging toxic positivity, as communicators try to outdo each other by showing how hard they work, how successful their careers are, or how they overcame personal struggles (Orgad, 2025; Orgad & Gill, 2022).

But negative emotions are part of life. As Emmons (2013) argued: “To deny that life has its share of disappointments, frustrations, losses, hurts, setbacks, and sadness would be unrealistic and untenable. Life is suffering. No amount of positive thinking exercises will change this truth” (Reframing disaster section). Exclusively sending positive messages can result in toxic positivity, leading to disillusionment, unhealthy social comparisons, and lower enjoyment of past experiences (Lew & Flanagan, 2025; Salopek & Eastin, 2024; Shipp & Hall, 2024).

Toxic positivity can happen due to several reasons. First, communicators who suppress negative emotions in favor of positive emotions merely manage what they express, not what they actually feel (Gross, 2002). Hence, the emotional labor of performing engenders in communicators a feeling of toxic positivity (Lew & Flanagan, 2025). Second, expressing positivity at the expense of negativity can result in cognitive dissonance, which is

unpleasant and contributes to a sense of toxic positivity (Lew & Flanagan, 2025). In self-effects research, cognitive dissonance is theorized to drive change: Communicators who self-present in a particular way avoid cognitive dissonance by changing their self-concepts, attitudes, or cognitions to match their self-presentations (Valkenburg, 2017). However, there is another possibility: Communicators who self-present in a positive way experience cognitive dissonance because their positive self-presentations did not acknowledge some partial elements of negativity. But instead of resolving the cognitive dissonance by changing themselves (i.e., reframe their cognitions to be more positive), communicators may resolve the cognitive dissonance by psychologically disavowing their self-presentations—that is, by lowering their commitment.

Communicators who engage in self-glorification may experience low authentic cognition because of the low unbiased processing, as defined by Kernis and Goldman (2006). That is, due to the embellishments, exaggerations, and self-promotion involved in self-glorification, communicators may experience toxic positivity as they compel themselves to be positive and/or suppress their negative emotions. This potentially lowers their enjoyment of the shared experience and they adopt the second approach of resolving cognitive dissonance: by disavowing their self-presentations (thus lowering their commitment). Conversely, self-presenting with mindfulness should result in more enjoyment and commitment due to greater authentic cognition (and less toxic positivity). Therefore:

H3: Toxic positivity mediates the relationship between self-presentation style and commitment, such that self-glorification (relative to mindfulness) is positively associated with toxic positivity, which in turn is negatively associated with commitment.

H4: Toxic positivity mediates the relationship between self-presentation style and enjoyment, such that self-glorification (relative to mindfulness) is positively associated with toxic

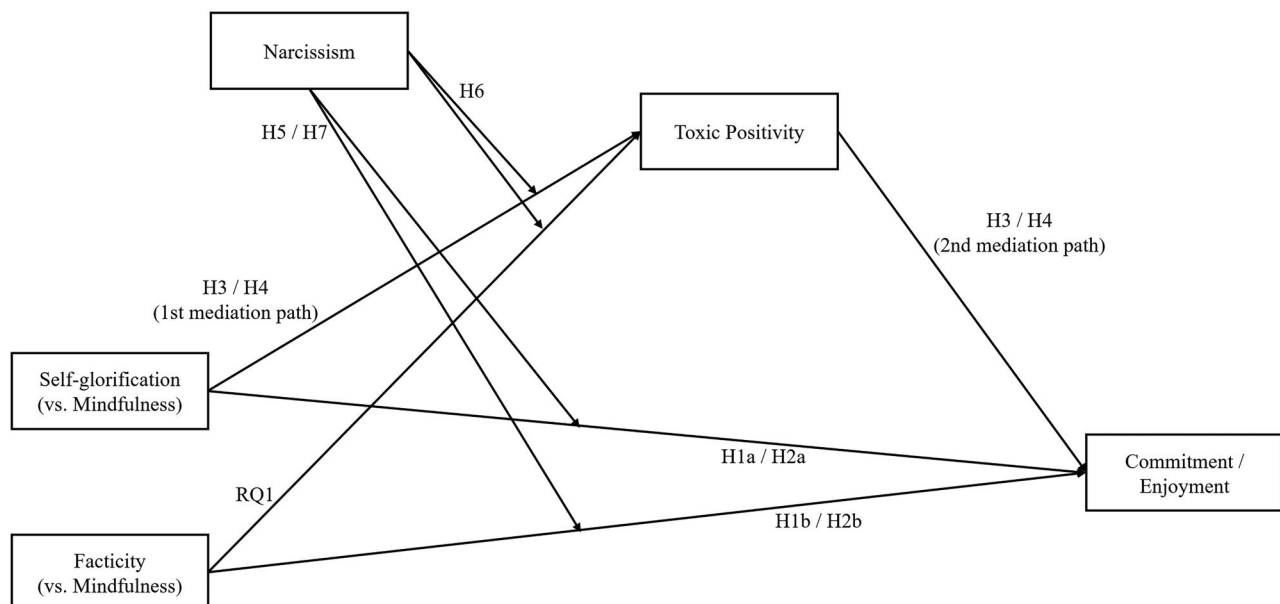


Figure 1 Diagrammatic representation of H1–H7 and RQ1.

positivity, which in turn is negatively associated with enjoyment.

It may be possible that self-presenting with facticity engenders a low level of pressure on communicators to positively portray themselves. People can attempt to make themselves look good by omitting unfavorable details while still being factual (Marsh & Tversky, 2004). Therefore:

RQ1: Does facticity lead to greater toxic positivity than mindfulness?

Narcissism

However, self-glorification may not elicit toxic positivity for all individuals: Speculatively, narcissists may enjoy self-glorification or desire to commit to self-presentations that are vastly superior to their perceived true selves. For narcissists, inauthentic self-expression may engender greater self-effects than authentic cognition/self-expression.

Narcissists may have greater enjoyment than non-narcissists if they were instructed to self-glorify, making narcissism a boundary condition to our earlier hypotheses (H1–H4). Narcissism—specifically, grandiose narcissism—is typically associated with the overestimation of one’s intellectual abilities, arrogance, high self-esteem, and “a zero-sum interpersonal approach, in which there can be only one winner” (Miller et al., 2021, p. 519). Narcissists are more motivated than non-narcissists to self-promote by using self-presentation tactics and are less likely to fear others’ negative evaluation (Hart et al., 2017). On social media, narcissists self-promote to a greater extent than non-narcissists via both text-based posts and photos (Mehdizadeh, 2010).

Given how narcissists enjoy self-promotion, they may not experience toxic positivity even if they self-glorified by exaggerating and adding embellishments. Instead, narcissistic individuals are more likely to positively evaluate the discrepancy between their self-presentations and their perceived true selves. Therefore, narcissism is a potential moderator that changes the effect of self-presentation style on the dependent variables, as well as the effect of self-presentation style on the mediator, toxic positivity:

H5: The effect of self-presentation style on commitment is moderated by narcissism. Among people who are less narcissistic, mindful self-presentations engender more commitment, and self-glorifying/factual self-presentations engender less; but among people who are more narcissistic, self-glorifying/factual self-presentations engender more commitment, and mindful self-presentations less.

H5 is expected to be a transverse moderation (Holbert & Park, 2020).

The same transverse moderation logic applies to the mediator, toxic positivity, and to people’s enjoyment of their self-presentations:

H6: The effect of self-presentation style on toxic positivity is moderated by narcissism. Among people who are less

narcissistic, mindful self-presentations engender less toxic positivity, and self-glorifying/factual self-presentations engender more; but among people who are more narcissistic, self-glorifying/factual self-presentations engender less toxic positivity, and mindful self-presentations more.

H7: The effect of self-presentation style on enjoyment is moderated by narcissism. Among people who are less narcissistic, mindful self-presentations engender more enjoyment, self-glorifying/factual self-presentations engender more enjoyment, and mindful self-presentations less.

See Figure 1 for a diagrammatic representation of H1–H7 and RQ1.

Method

Sample

Participants ($N=229$) were students at Nanyang Technological University, Singapore. Assuming a medium effect size, at least 159 participants are required to compare group means across three experimental groups with 80% power.⁶ Participants’ ages ranged from 18 to 33 years ($M=22.29$, $SD=2.30$), with four participants not reporting their age. 59.83% of participants were male, 37.12% were female, and 3.06% were non-binary or did not indicate their sex. The recruitment message was disseminated through university emails and Telegram channels. Participants had to be LinkedIn users as the study required them to post on their actual LinkedIn accounts. They were paid \$15 in the local currency (approximately \$11 US dollars) after completing the study.

Procedure

Participants read the consent form, then answered the NPI-16 (i.e., the measure for narcissism). Next, they were told they had to create a LinkedIn post on their actual accounts, detailing “a recent learning experience where you witnessed significant personal growth through a challenging time.”

Thereafter, participants were randomly assigned to one of three possible conditions: mindfulness, facticity, or self-glorification. The mindfulness condition read: “As you write about your learning experience, describe the emotions you felt during this experience and explain, as objectively as possible, why you felt those emotions. Write in a balanced manner, and from a place of non-judgment. Be present as you recall and describe your experience, acknowledging your emotions without attachment.” The facticity condition read: “As you write about your learning experience, describe what happened and who was involved in a completely factual way. The aim is to be as factual and unemotional as possible in your description of the experience.” The self-glorification condition read: “As you write about your learning experience, exaggerate your own qualities and add embellishments to what you’ve learned. Make yourself seem really impressive. The aim is to focus on self-glorification.” Participants had to write at least 150 words in their posts.

After creating the LinkedIn post, participants pasted the full text into the questionnaire and emailed a screenshot of the post to the researchers for verification. Finally, participants completed the remaining measures.

Measures

Narcissism was assessed using the NPI-16 (Ames et al., 2006), which comprised 16 pairs of statements (e.g., “I like to be the center of attention/I prefer to blend in with the crowd”). Each pair consisted of a non-narcissistic statement (coded 0) and a narcissistic statement (coded 1). Participants selected the statement that better reflected their personality. Each participant’s narcissism score was the mean of all 16 items, $KR-20=.71$.

Toxic positivity comprised five items from Lew and Flanagin (2025). The question stem, “The LinkedIn post I made,” was followed by items rated from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), such as: “Fails to acknowledge the hardships in life” and “Pressures me to be positive,” Cronbach’s $\alpha=.85$.

Enjoyment comprised five items on a 7-point semantic differential scale adapted from Lew and Flanagin (2025). The question stem, “How do you feel about the overall experience depicted in your post? It was:” was followed by *unpleasant–pleasant*, *unenjoyable–enjoyable*, *dissatisfying–satisfying*, *uninteresting–interesting*, and *not valuable–valuable*. Cronbach’s $\alpha=.91$.

Commitment comprised three items on a 7-point semantic differential scale (Lew & Flanagin, 2025). The question stem read, “Think of the way you portrayed yourself in your post.” Participants then answered three questions: “How committed are you to maintaining this image of yourself in the future?” (*very uncommitted–very committed*), “How consistent with this portrayal do you think you will be in your future self-portrayals?” (*very inconsistent–very consistent*), and “How differently would you portray yourself in the future?” (*very differently–very similarly*). Cronbach’s $\alpha=.89$.

Authenticity was measured using a single item, “In my LinkedIn post, I feel authentic in the way I presented myself,” scored from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*).

See Tables OSM1, OSM2, and OSM3 in the Online Supplemental Materials for the descriptive statistics.

Results

Manipulation check

A one-way ANOVA tested the effect of self-presentation style on perceived authenticity, $F(2, 226) = 20.88$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2=.16$. Holm-adjusted post hoc tests showed that the mindfulness condition ($M=5.73$, $SD=1.24$) engendered greater perceived authenticity than the facticity condition ($M=5.13$, $SD=1.41$), $t(226)=2.41$, $p=.017$. The facticity condition also engendered greater perceived authenticity than the self-glorification condition ($M=4.15$, $SD=1.93$), $t(226)=3.77$, $p < .001$. Finally, the difference between the mindfulness condition and the self-glorification condition was also significant, $t(226)=6.44$, $p < .001$.

Hypothesis tests

Self-presentation style was represented by two dummy variables, and coded using simple effect coding. In the first dummy variable, mindfulness = $-1/3$, self-glorification = $2/3$, and facticity = $-1/3$. In the second dummy variable, mindfulness = $-1/3$, self-glorification = $-1/3$, and facticity = $2/3$. Therefore, the mindfulness condition was the reference category, which was compared to the self-glorification condition in the first dummy variable and to the facticity condition in the second dummy variable. Toxic positivity and narcissism were mean-centered. All mediation tests utilized 10,000 bootstrapped samples.

Main effect of self-presentation type on commitment

An ANOVA tested the main effect of self-presentation style on commitment (H1). Results were statistically significant, $F(2, 226) = 7.46$, $p = .001$, $\eta^2 = .06$. Holm-adjusted post hoc tests showed that participants in the mindfulness condition ($M = 5.38$, $SD = 1.18$) had more commitment than participants in the self-glorification condition ($M = 4.52$, $SD = 1.76$), $t(226) = 3.80$, $p = .001$. Hence, H1a was supported. However, participants in the mindfulness condition did not report more commitment than participants in the facticity condition ($M = 5.14$, $SD = 1.30$), $t(226) = 1.07$, $p = .287$. H1b was unsupported. Notably, participants in the facticity condition had more commitment than participants in the self-glorification condition, $t(226) = 2.56$, $p = .022$.

Moderated mediation effects on commitment: narcissism and toxic positivity

Model 8 of Hayes’s (2022) PROCESS⁷ was used to test the moderated mediation effect on commitment, represented by H3, H5, H6, and RQ1 (see Figure 1). Self-presentation style was the independent variable, toxic positivity was the mediator, narcissism was the moderator, and commitment was the dependent variable.

The results consisted of two regression models, one predicting toxic positivity and another predicting commitment. The model predicting toxic positivity tested whether narcissism moderated the effect of self-presentation type on toxic positivity (H6) and whether facticity led to greater toxic positivity than mindfulness (RQ1). The model predicting commitment tested whether narcissism moderated the effect of self-presentation type on commitment (H5). The two models provided the paths for PROCESS to create bootstrapped indirect effects that determined whether toxic positivity mediated the relationship between self-presentation style and commitment (H3). Below, we report the most important parts of the results (see Table 1 for the full results).

The model predicting toxic positivity was significant, $R^2 = .10$, $F(5, 223) = 4.82$, $p < .001$. Participants who self-glorified experienced greater toxic positivity than participants who self-presented with mindfulness, $b = 0.72$, $p < .001$. However, none of the other predictors—including the interaction between each dummy variable and narcissism—were significant. Therefore, H6 and RQ1 were unsupported.

The model predicting commitment was significant, $R^2 = .18$, $F(6, 222) = 8.05$, $p < .001$. As the interaction between self-presentation style and narcissism was non-significant, H5 was unsupported.

Table 1 Narcissism and toxic positivity: a moderated mediation model predicting commitment (PROCESS Model 8).Toxic positivity: $R^2=.10$, $F(5, 223) = 4.82$, $p<.001$

	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Intercept	0.01	0.09	0.15	.882
Self-glorification	0.72	0.20	3.51	<.001
Facticity (RQ1)	−0.18	0.21	−0.85	.397
Narcissism	0.13	0.48	0.27	.791
Self-glorification × Narcissism (H6)	−1.96	1.04	−1.88	.061
Facticity × Narcissism (H6)	0.29	1.22	0.24	.811

Commitment: $R^2=.18$, $F(6, 222) = 8.05$, $p<.001$

	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Intercept	5.01	0.09	56.28	<.001
Self-glorification	−0.67	0.22	−3.06	.003
Facticity	−0.30	0.22	−1.41	.161
Toxic positivity	−0.29	0.07	−4.10	<.001
Narcissism	0.36	0.50	0.72	.473
Self-glorification × Narcissism (H5)	1.85	1.10	1.69	.093
Facticity × Narcissism (H5)	−2.05	1.28	−1.61	.110

Indirect effects

	Effect	<i>SE</i> _{boot}	95% <i>CI</i> _{boot}
Self-glorification → Toxic positivity → Commitment (H3)	−0.21	0.09	[−0.412, −0.067]
Index of moderated mediation (self-glorification vs. mindfulness)	0.56	0.36	[−0.050, 1.346]
Facticity → Toxic positivity → Commitment	0.05	0.06	[−0.065, 0.172]
Index of moderated mediation (facticity vs. mindfulness)	−0.08	0.39	[−0.932, 0.660]

Note. *Self-glorification* and *facticity* refer to the dummy variables. *Mindfulness* was the reference condition. Indirect effects were estimated at the median value of narcissism. Bold values indicate statistical significance.

Finally, we examine the mediation effect (H3). Holding narcissism at the median (i.e., controlling for narcissism), there was a significant indirect effect of self-presentation style (only self-glorification vs. mindfulness) on commitment, through toxic positivity, indirect effect = −0.21, $SE_{bootstrapped} = 0.09$, 95% $CI_{bootstrapped} = [−0.412, −0.067]$. Participants who self-glorified experienced greater toxic positivity than participants who self-presented mindfully, and greater toxic positivity was associated with less commitment to one's self-presentation, supporting H3. There was no significant indirect effect through toxic positivity when facticity was compared to mindfulness. There was no significant moderated mediation effect.

Main effect of self-presentation type on enjoyment

An ANOVA tested the main effect of self-presentation style on enjoyment (H2). Results were statistically significant, $F(2, 226) = 5.31$, $p = .006$, $\eta^2 = .04$. Holm-adjusted post hoc tests showed that participants in the mindfulness condition ($M = 5.45$, $SD = 1.15$) reported greater enjoyment of the shared experience than participants in the self-glorification condition ($M = 4.80$, $SD = 1.44$), $t(226) = 3.26$, $p = .004$. Hence, H2a was supported. However, participants in the mindfulness condition did not report greater enjoyment than participants in the facticity condition ($M = 5.16$, $SD = 1.19$), $t(226) = 1.43$, $p = .179$. H2b was unsupported. Participants in the self-glorification condition also

did not differ from participants in the facticity condition in terms of enjoyment, $t(226) = 1.71$, $p = .179$.

Moderated mediation effects on enjoyment: narcissism and toxic positivity

Model 5 of Hayes's (2022) PROCESS was used to test the moderated mediation effect on enjoyment, represented by H4 and H7 (see Figure 1). PROCESS Model 5 was used instead of Model 8 because H6 (whether narcissism moderated the effect of self-presentation type on toxic positivity) was already tested in the previous analysis. Self-presentation style was the independent variable, toxic positivity was the mediator, narcissism was the moderator, and enjoyment was the dependent variable.

The results consisted of two regression models, one predicting toxic positivity and another predicting enjoyment. The model predicting toxic positivity was necessary for the mediation test, but it did not address a specific hypothesis. The model predicting enjoyment tested for whether narcissism moderated the effect of self-presentation type on enjoyment (H7). The two models allowed PROCESS to then test whether toxic positivity mediated the relationship between self-presentation style and enjoyment (H4). See Table 2.

The model predicting toxic positivity was significant, $R^2 = .08$, $F(2, 226) = 9.60$, $p < .001$. The model predicting enjoyment was also significant, $R^2 = .15$, $F(6, 222) = 6.48$, $p < .001$. The interaction

between the self-glorification dummy variable and narcissism predicting enjoyment was significant, $b = 2.36$, $p = .017$. To probe the significant interaction effect, simple slopes analyses were performed using the emmeans package (see Figure 2). Results showed that the slope for self-glorification was significantly different from a horizontal line, $b = 2.14$, $p = .004$, but the slopes for mindfulness and facticity were not, $b = -0.70$, $p = .316$ and $b = -1.38$, $p = .151$, respectively. Thus, the interaction was attributable to the trend that as participants' level of narcissism increases, their enjoyment also increases if they self-glorified in their self-presentations. Figure 2, which depicts the interaction, revealed a transverse pattern.

We also probed the effect of mindfulness vs. self-glorification on enjoyment at low (-1 SD), average (mean), and high ($+1$ SD) levels of narcissism. The exact values for low, average, and high narcissism were -0.184 , 0 , and 0.184 , respectively (recall that narcissism was mean-centered). At a low narcissism level, participants in the mindfulness condition reported greater enjoyment than those in the self-glorification condition, $b = 1.19$, $p < .001$. At an average narcissism level, participants in the mindfulness condition also reported greater enjoyment than those in the self-glorification condition, $b = 0.67$, $p = .002$ —but the difference had a smaller magnitude than at a low narcissism level. At a high narcissism level, there was no significant difference between participants in the mindfulness condition and those in the self-glorification condition, $b = 0.14$, $p = .854$. As a whole, the self-glorification vs. mindfulness contrast was consistent with H7, but the facticity vs. mindfulness contrast was not. Full results of the simple slopes probe and the contrasts probe can be found in Table OSM4 (see Online Supplemental Materials).

As for the mediation test (H4), there was a significant indirect effect of self-presentation style (only self-glorification vs. mindfulness) on enjoyment, through toxic positivity, indirect effect = -0.17 , $SE_{\text{bootstrapped}} = 0.08$, 95% $CI_{\text{bootstrapped}} = [-0.345, -0.045]$. Participants who self-glorified experienced greater toxic positivity than participants who self-presented mindfully, and greater toxic positivity was associated with less enjoyment. Thus, H4 was supported. There was no significant indirect effect through toxic positivity when facticity was compared to mindfulness.

Discussion

The present research aimed to do two things. First, it sought to understand what role authenticity plays in self-effects. Based on prior research (e.g., Kernis & Goldman, 2006; Kreling et al., 2022), we conceptualized authenticity as having two overarching dimensions: authentic cognition and authentic self-expression. We then induced in participants one of three possible self-presentation motivations designed to represent varying levels of authentic cognition and authentic self-expression: mindfulness, facticity, and self-glorification. Second, this research aimed to expand the scope of self-effects research to include cognitive-affective outcomes, such as enjoyment and commitment. These aims were fulfilled in several ways.

People who self-presented a past learning experience with mindfulness experienced greater recalled enjoyment and greater commitment to self-present similarly in the future than people who did so with self-glorification, supporting H1a and H2a. Given that mindfulness corresponded to greater authenticity and self-glorification corresponded to lesser authenticity,

Table 2 Narcissism and toxic positivity: a model predicting enjoyment (PROCESS Model 5).

Toxic positivity: $R^2 = .08$, $F(2, 226) = 9.60$, $p < .001$

	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Intercept	0.01	0.09	0.09	.928
Self-glorification	0.71	0.20	3.46	<.001
Facticity	-0.18	0.21	-0.86	.390

Enjoyment: $R^2 = .15$, $F(6, 222) = 6.48$, $p < .001$

	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Intercept	5.13	0.08	64.26	<.001
Self-glorification	-0.49	0.20	-2.52	.013
Facticity	-0.34	0.19	-1.75	.082
Toxic positivity	-0.24	0.06	-3.84	<.001
Narcissism	0.05	0.45	0.11	.910
Self-glorification × Narcissism (H7)	2.36	0.98	2.40	.017
Facticity × Narcissism (H7)	-0.61	1.15	-0.53	.593

Indirect effects

	Effect	SE_{boot}	95% CI_{boot}
Self-glorification → Toxic positivity → Enjoyment (H4)	-0.17	0.08	[-0.345, -0.045]
Facticity → Toxic positivity → Enjoyment	0.04	0.05	[-0.053, 0.154]

Note. Self-glorification and facticity refer to the dummy variables. Mindfulness was the reference condition. Bold values indicate statistical significance.

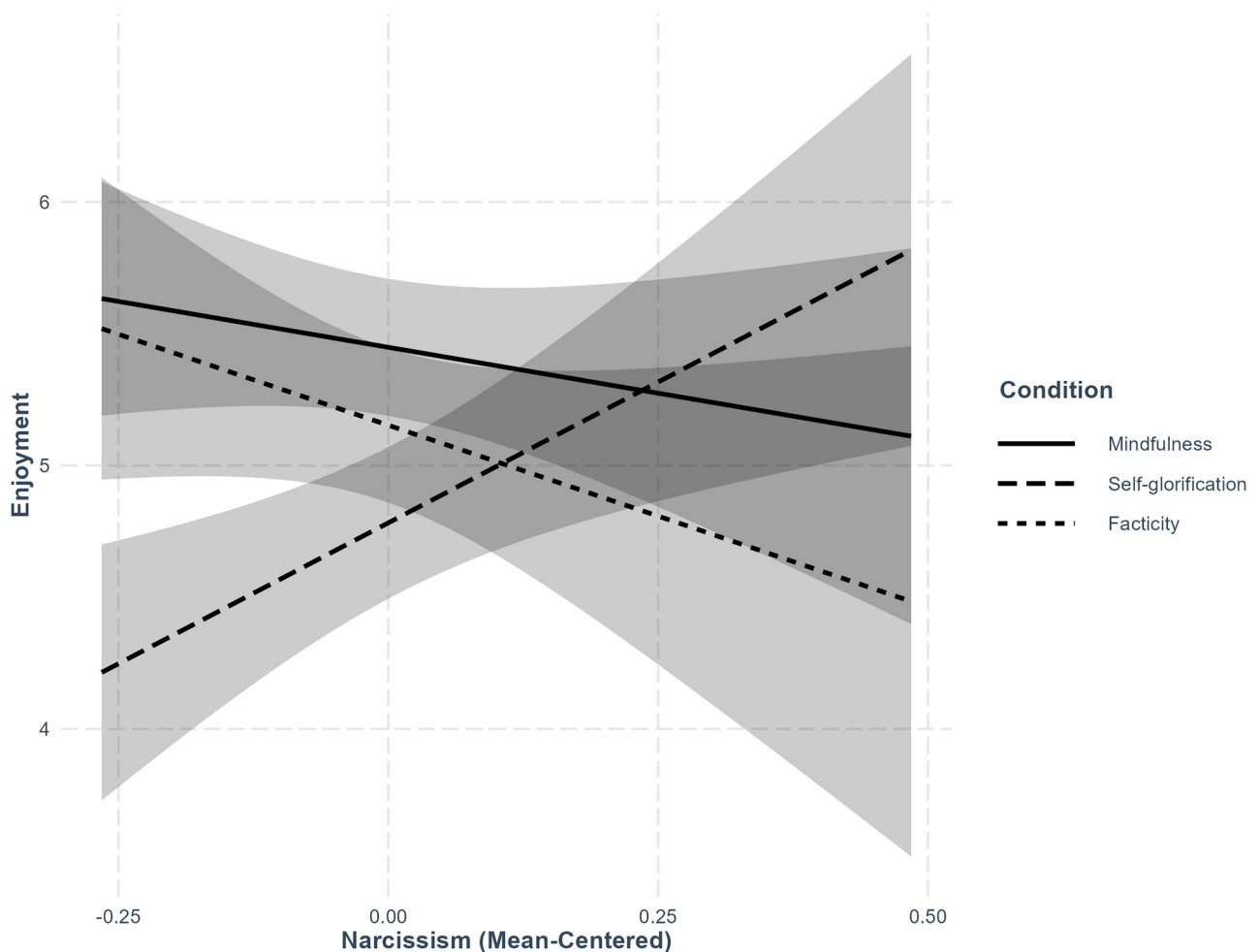


Figure 2 Influence of self-presentation style and narcissism on enjoyment.

this result showed support for Carr et al.'s (2021) assertion that self-presentations must be authentic. Additionally, this research clarified that authentic self-presentations are more than merely not lying or telling the truth. This was demonstrated in the experimental induction for mindfulness, which involves being aware of one's inner states (such as one's emotions and self-presentational motives) and thinking about those inner states with balance, acceptance, and crucially, without distortion (Kernis & Goldman, 2006). Mindfully thinking about what to self-present prior to the act of self-presentation is one way by which authentic self-presentations are achieved, suggesting that authentic self-presentations can have cognitive origins that deserve scholarly attention—above and beyond the content of the self-presentations.

The mediation tests (for H3 and H4) showed that compared to mindfulness, self-glorification was associated with greater toxic positivity, which in turn was associated with lower commitment to one's self-presentations and lower enjoyment of the experience described in the message. Self-presentations on social media can be done selectively, which allows communicators to put out the best version of themselves within the constraints of believability (Walther, 2007). In so doing, communicators bridge the discrepancy between who they perceive themselves to be and who they would ideally like to be, subject to role constraints

(Higgins, 1987). Yet, how people's self-presentations are perceived by audiences is only one facet of things. This study showed that self-glorification comes at a cost to communicators as they think about themselves and self-present to others in an inauthentic way, that is, as they engage in inauthentic cognition and inauthentic self-expression. Conversely, communicators who self-presented with mindfulness experienced less toxic positivity, had greater enjoyment, and were more committed to their self-presentations. Being able to perceive oneself with balance and acceptance, and thereafter send messages aligned with these self-perceptions, can shape one's enjoyment of the experience described in one's message.

Additionally, the results showed that narcissism was a moderator when comparing the effect of self-glorification vs. mindfulness on enjoyment (but not when comparing facticity vs. mindfulness). Specifically, the support for H7 (see Figure 2) showed that self-glorification was associated with less enjoyment than mindfulness, but only among people lower in narcissism and not among people higher in narcissism. We tested narcissism to find out whether our earlier arguments on authenticity had a boundary condition: Is it possible that some people may prefer making inauthentic self-presentations to authentic ones? The significant moderation result can add nuance to the scholarly thinking on authentic self-presentations within

identity shift theory. Perhaps some groups of people may experience greater identity shift when they do not self-present authentically. Future research can consider identifying other groups of people or exploring other boundary conditions.

The facticity manipulation had mostly null findings. Relative to the mindfulness condition, it did not yield any statistically significant differences (see results for H2b and H1b, and [Tables 1 and 2](#)). Recall that participants in the facticity condition were instructed to be factual and unemotional in their self-presentations. However, authenticity involves more than facticity alone. Authenticity requires people to be aware and accepting of their own emotions or cognitions ([Kernis & Goldman, 2006](#)). Put differently, facticity met only the criterion of authentic self-expression, but not that of authentic cognition. Telling the factual truth, which was the case with participants in the facticity condition, is not authenticity ([Kernis & Goldman, 2006](#); [Kreling et al., 2022](#)). The null findings vis-à-vis facticity do not allow us to make inferences relative to mindfulness. However, a post hoc comparison done as part of the ANOVA to analyze H1 revealed that the facticity condition engendered greater commitment (but not greater enjoyment) than the self-glorification condition. This finding showed that some degree of authentic self-expression (as represented by facticity) is sufficient to engender greater commitment, even when authentic cognition is low. Thus, the two-dimensional conceptualization of authenticity, comprising authentic cognition and authentic self-expression, is useful in that the two dimensions do not necessarily covary positively. Either authentic cognition or authentic self-expression, on its own, may engender self-effects. What remains unclear is the extent to which meeting the criterion of authentic cognition but not that of authentic self-expression (i.e., a reversal of the aspects of authenticity met by the facticity condition) can influence enjoyment or commitment. Simply put, more research is needed to find out whether both authentic cognition and authentic self-expression are necessary to produce particular self-effects, or whether one of them is sufficient.

This study has several limitations. One limitation of the present research is that the experimental treatment did not always delineate between authentic cognition and authentic self-expression, as the mindfulness manipulation tapped into both concepts. Future research can attempt to test the extent to which each of these concepts is necessary and/or sufficient to engender self-effects. Relatedly, another limitation is the one-item manipulation check for authenticity. Given the conceptual complexities surrounding authenticity, a more comprehensive measure of authenticity should have been used. The present study also utilized a posttest-only design, which assumed that random assignment to condition equalized all groups at the beginning of the study—and hence, any posttest differences could be attributed to self-effects. Future studies can adopt a pretest-posttest design (e.g., [Johnson & Rosenbaum, 2023](#)) to empirically measure changes due to the experimental induction. Lastly, there is some conceptual overlap between the measure for toxic positivity (e.g., “The LinkedIn post I made pressures me to be positive”) and the experimental instruction for the self-glorification condition. To wit, instructing participants to embellish and self-promote may have contributed to some pressure to be positive. It is therefore possible that participants’ responses on the toxic positivity measure partially reflected their

acknowledgement of the experimental instructions. Future work should aim to separate adjacent constructs such as message valence, self-enhancement, emotional suppression, and authenticity, so that people’s interpretations of experimental instructions do not bleed into the mediators or outcome variables.

When viewed in the broader context of self-effects, this study is an attempt at integrating ideas from identity shift ([Carr et al., 2021](#)), expressive writing ([Pennebaker & Chung, 2011](#)), and to a lesser extent, political deliberation ([Pingree, 2007](#)). Crucially, it demonstrated that authenticity plays an important role in the study of self-effects, alongside more established factors such as publicness and feedback. This study also showed that authenticity has cognitive and expressive elements for communicators. Therefore, the thoughts that go into crafting a message may be just as influential in producing self-effects as the content of the message or the relationship between communicators and audiences.

Notes

1. Or what [Valkenburg \(2017\)](#) termed “political deliberation.”
2. That is, authentic cognition and authentic self-expression as experienced by communicators, and not as perceived by audiences.
3. Mindfulness is not authenticity, but given the high correlation between mindfulness and authenticity, we induced authenticity in our participants via a mindfulness induction. A more direct instruction, such as “be authentic,” would be *prima facie* too vague. See the Method section for details.
4. Examples may be helpful here. Suppose a communicator had a personal experience where they made an error in a report, and that error was caught by their manager. A mindful message may be: “Submitted a report with an error this week. My manager caught it before it went to the client. It’s a little frustrating, but these things happen. It’s a good reminder to slow down and be more careful.” A message written with facticity may be: “Submitted a report with an error this week. My manager caught it before it went to the client.” A self-glorification message may be: “My manager caught an error in my report this week. Embarrassing? A little. But I took a step back, revamped my whole work process, and came out with a system that’s better. Sometimes the small slip-ups are the ones that push you to level up 🦋” These examples were generated by Claude, then edited by the authors.
5. Independent of how positively or negatively audiences perceive a communicator’s self-glorification attempt.
6. Using G*Power, we selected: *F*-tests, one-way ANOVA, *f* = .25, power = .80, number of groups = 3.
7. The coding scheme was implemented using the `mcx = 5` command.

Supplementary material

[Supplementary material](#) is available at *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication* online.

Data availability

Materials from this study will be shared upon reasonable request made to the corresponding author.

Funding

The author(s) disclosed receipt of the following financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article: This work was supported by the Singapore Ministry of Education Academic Research Fund (AcRF Tier 1) [RS09/22].

Conflicts of interest

The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Ethics approval

IRB-2022-961.

References

- Allan, B. A., Bott, E. M., & Suh, H. (2015). Connecting mindfulness and meaning in life: Exploring the role of authenticity. *Mindfulness*, 6, 996–1003. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12671-014-0341-z>
- Ames, D. R., Rose, P., & Anderson, C. P. (2006). The NPI-16 as a short measure of narcissism. *Journal of Research in Personality*, 40, 440–450. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrp.2005.03.002>
- Baikie, K. A., & Wilhelm, K. (2005). Emotional and physical health benefits of expressive writing. *Advances in Psychiatric Treatment*, 11, 338–346. <https://doi.org/10.1192/apt.11.5.338>
- Brown, K. W., Ryan, R. M., & Creswell, J. D. (2007). Mindfulness: Theoretical foundations and evidence for its salutary effects. *Psychological Inquiry*, 18, 211–237. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10478400701598298>
- Carr, C. T., & Hayes, R. A. (2019). Identity shift effects of self-presentation and confirmatory and disconfirmatory feedback on self-perceptions of brand identification. *Media Psychology*, 22, 418–444. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2017.1396228>
- Carr, C. T., Kim, Y., Valov, J. J., Rosenbaum, J. E., Johnson, B. K., Hancock, J. T., & Gonzales, A. L. (2021). An explication of identity shift theory. *Journal of Media Psychology*, 33, 202–214. <https://doi.org/10.1027/1864-1105/a000314>
- Chen, S., & Murphy, D. (2019). The mediating role of authenticity on mindfulness and wellbeing: A cross cultural analysis. *Asia Pacific Journal of Counselling and Psychotherapy*, 10, 40–55. <https://doi.org/10.1080/21507686.2018.1556171>
- Choi, S., Williams, D., & Kim, H. (2026). A snap of your true self: How self-presentation and temporal affordance influence self-concept on social media. *New Media & Society*, 28, 4327–4348. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444820977199>
- Diehl, K., Zauberman, G., & Barasch, A. (2016). How taking photos increases enjoyment of experiences. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 111, 119–140. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspa0000055>
- Emmons, R. (2013, May 13). How gratitude can help you through hard times. *Greater Good Science Magazine*. https://greatergood.berkeley.edu/article/item/how_gratitude_can_help_you_through_hard_times
- Erickson, R. J. (1995). The importance of authenticity for self and society. *Symbolic Interaction*, 18, 121–144. <https://doi.org/10.1525/si.1995.18.2.121>
- Gonzales, A. L., & Hancock, J. T. (2008). Identity shift in computer-mediated environments. *Media Psychology*, 11, 167–185. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213260802023433>
- Gross, J. J. (2002). Emotion regulation: Affective, cognitive, and social consequences. *Psychophysiology*, 39, 281–291. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0048577201393198>
- Hart, W., Adams, J., Burton, K. A., & Tortoriello, G. K. (2017). Narcissism and self-presentation: Profiling grandiose and vulnerable narcissists' self-presentation tactic use. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 104, 48–57. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2016.06.062>
- Hayes, A. F. (2022). *Introduction to mediation, moderation, and conditional process analysis: A regression-based approach* (3rd ed.). The Guilford Press.
- Higgins, E. T. (1987). Self-discrepancy: A theory relating self and affect. *Psychological Review*, 94, 319–340. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.94.3.319>
- Holbert, R. L., & Park, E. (2020). Conceptualizing, organizing, and positing moderation in communication research. *Communication Theory*, 30, 227–246. <https://doi.org/10.1093/ct/qtz006>
- Johnson, B. K., & Rosenbaum, J. E. (2023). Sharing brands on social media: The roles of behavioural commitment and modality in identity shift. *International Journal of Consumer Studies*, 47, 995–1010. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ijcs.12880>
- Johnson, B. K., & Van Der Heide, B. (2015). Can sharing affect liking? Online taste performances, feedback, and subsequent media preferences. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 46, 181–190. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2015.01.018>
- Kernis, M. H., & Goldman, B. M. (2006). A multicomponent conceptualization of authenticity: Theory and research. *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, 38, 283–357. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601\(06\)38006-9](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38006-9)
- Kim, E., & McDonald-Liu, C. (2023). Influencers with# NoFilter: How micro-celebrities use self-branding practices on Instagram. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 148, 107892. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2023.107892>
- Kreling, R., Meier, A., & Reinecke, L. (2022). Feeling authentic on social media: Subjective authenticity across Instagram stories and posts. *Social Media + Society*, 8. <https://doi.org/10.1177/205630512211086235>
- Lane, D. S., Moxley, C. M., Petro, G., & Jagayat, A. (2025). A longitudinal test of political self-effects on social media. *Media Psychology*, 28, 5–28. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2024.2319588>
- Langston, C. A. (1994). Capitalizing on and coping with daily-life events: Expressive responses to positive events. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 67, 1112–1125. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.67.6.1112>

- Lee, E.-J. (2020). Authenticity model of (mass-oriented) computer-mediated communication: Conceptual explorations and testable propositions. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, 25, 60–73. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jcmc/zmz025>
- Lew, Z., & Flanagin, A. J. (2024). Self-effects and public commitment on social media: Testing the cognitive and social influences of sending messages on message senders. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 156, 108200. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2024.108200>
- Lew, Z., & Flanagin, A. J. (2025). Toxic positivity on social media: The drawbacks and benefits of sharing positive (but potentially platitudinous) messages online. *New Media & Society*, 27, 2972–2995. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448231213944>
- Marsh, E. J., & Tversky, B. (2004). Spinning the stories of our lives. *Applied Cognitive Psychology*, 18, 491–503. <https://doi.org/10.1002/acp.1001>
- Medlock, G. (2012). The evolving ethic of authenticity: From humanistic to positive psychology. *The Humanistic Psychologist*, 40, 38–57. <https://doi.org/10.1080/08873267.2012.643687>
- Mehdizadeh, S. (2010). Self-presentation 2.0: Narcissism and self-esteem on Facebook. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking*, 13, 357–364. <https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2009.0257>
- Miller, J. D., Back, M. D., Lynam, D. R., & Wright, A. G. (2021). Narcissism today: What we know and what we need to learn. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 30, 519–525. <https://doi.org/10.1177/096372142111044109>
- Orgad, S. (2025). Posting vulnerability on LinkedIn. *New Media & Society*, 27, 4822–4841. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448241243094>
- Orgad, S., & Gill, R. (2022). *Confidence culture*. Duke University Press.
- Pennebaker, J. W., & Chung, C. K. (2011). Expressive writing: Connections to physical and mental health. In H. S. Friedman (Ed.), *The Oxford handbook of health psychology* (pp. 417–437). Oxford University Press.
- Peña, J., & Hill, D. (2020). Examining identity shift effects in virtual reality. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking*, 23, 697–701. <https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2020.0010>
- Pingree, R. J. (2007). How messages affect their senders: A more general model of message effects and implications for deliberation. *Communication Theory*, 17, 439–461. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2885.2007.00306.x>
- Ryan, W. S., & Ryan, R. M. (2019). Toward a social psychology of authenticity: Exploring within-person variation in autonomy, congruence, and genuineness using self-determination theory. *Review of General Psychology*, 23, 99–112. <https://doi.org/10.1037/gpr0000162>
- Salisbury, M., & Pooley, J. D. (2017). The #nofilter self: The contest for authenticity among social networking sites, 2002–2016. *Social Sciences*, 6, 10. <https://doi.org/10.3390/socsci6010010>
- Salopek, A. H., & Eastin, M. S. (2024). Toxic positivity intentions: An image management approach to upward social comparison and false self-presentation. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, 29, zmae003. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jcmc/zmae003>
- Schlenker, B. R. (1986). Self-presentation: Toward an integration of the private and public self. In R. F. Baumeister (Ed.), *Public self and private self* (pp. 21–62). Springer-Verlag.
- Schlenker, B. R. (2012). Self-presentation. In M. R. Leary, & J. P. Tangney (Eds.), *Handbook of self and identity* (2nd ed., pp. 542–570). Guilford Press.
- Shipp, H. G., & Hall, K. C. (2024). Analyzing the concept of toxic positivity for nursing: A dimensional analysis approach. *Journal of Advanced Nursing*, 80, 3146–3157. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jan.16057>
- Thibaut, J. W., & Kelley, H. H. (1959). *The social psychology of groups*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Travagin, G., Margola, D., & Revenson, T. A. (2015). How effective are expressive writing interventions for adolescents? A meta-analytic review. *Clinical Psychology Review*, 36, 42–55. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cpr.2015.01.003>
- Valkenburg, P. M. (2017). Understanding self-effects in social media. *Human Communication Research*, 43, 477–490. <https://doi.org/10.1111/hcre.12113>
- Vansteenkiste, M., Aelterman, N., De Mynck, G. J., Haerens, L., Patall, E., & Reeve, J. (2018). Fostering personal meaning and self-relevance: A self-determination theory perspective on internalization. *The Journal of Experimental Education*, 86, 30–49. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00220973.2017.1381067>
- Walther, J. B. (2007). Selective self-presentation in computer-mediated communication: Hyperpersonal dimensions of technology, language, and cognition. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 23, 2538–2557. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2006.05.002>
- Walther, J. B., Liang, Y. J., DeAndrea, D. C., Tong, S. T., Carr, C. T., Spottswood, E. L., & Amichai-Hamburger, Y. (2011). The effect of feedback on identity shift in computer-mediated communication. *Media Psychology*, 14, 1–26. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2010.547832>
- Waterloo, S. F., Baumgartner, S. E., Peter, J., & Valkenburg, P. M. (2018). Norms of online expressions of emotion: Comparing Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, and WhatsApp. *New Media & Society*, 20, 1813–1831. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444817707349>
- Wing, J. F., Schutte, N. S., & Byrne, B. (2006). The effect of positive writing on emotional intelligence and life satisfaction. *Journal of Clinical Psychology*, 62, 1291–1302. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jclp.20292>
- Winter, S., Rimmelswaal, P., & Vos, A. (2022). When posting is believing. *Journal of Media Psychology*, 34, 177–187. <https://doi.org/10.1027/1864-1105/a000308>

Online Supplemental Materials

Table OSM1

Means and Standard Deviations of All Continuous Items

Item	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Enjoyment (combined scale)	5.16	1.29
1. Unpleasant-Pleasant	5.15	1.50
2. Unenjoyable-Enjoyable	5.06	1.55
3. Dissatisfying-Satisfying	5.14	1.46
4. Uninteresting-Interesting	5.13	1.54
5. Not valuable-Valuable	5.31	1.50
Commitment (combined scale)	5.04	1.46
6. Very uncommitted-Very committed	5.24	1.61
7. Very inconsistent-Very consistent	5.04	1.56
8. Very differently-Very similarly	4.84	1.65
Toxic Positivity (combined scale)	3.72	1.34
9. Fails to acknowledge the hardships in life	3.42	1.63
10. Is unrealistically optimistic	3.79	1.80
11. Pressures me to be positive	4.36	1.70
12. Alienates me from my true feelings	3.76	1.74
13. Ignores the challenges I'm facing	3.28	1.58
Narcissism (combined scale)	0.26	0.18

Note. Means and standard deviations for the individual items in the narcissism scale were not reported as the items were dichotomous.

Table OSM2*Bivariate Pearson's Correlations Between All Continuous Variables*

Item	1	2	3
1. Enjoyment	-		
2. Commitment	.63*	-	
3. Toxic Positivity	-.30*	-.33*	-
4. Narcissism	.03	.08	.01

Note. * $p < .001$.**Table OSM3***Bivariate Pearson's Correlations Between All Continuous Items*

Item	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Pleasant	-						
2. Enjoyable	.71	-					
3. Satisfying	.71	.71	-				
4. Interesting	.57	.66	.65	-			
5. Valuable	.58	.62	.65	.71	-		
6. Very committed	.58	.55	.52	.44	.45	-	
7. Very consistent	.57	.56	.55	.46	.54	.83	-
8. Very similarly	.46	.44	.44	.36	.37	.66	.71
9. Fails to acknowledge	-.14	-.14	-.17	-.18	-.23	-.24	-.26
10. Unrealistically optimistic	-.27	-.29	-.33	-.25	-.31	-.36	-.41
11. Pressures me	-.07	-.07	-.09	-.05	-.20	-.03	-.09
12. Alienates me	-.28	-.25	-.30	-.19	-.28	-.30	-.40
13. Ignores the challenges	-.13	-.15	-.24	-.23	-.28	-.21	-.27

Note. Refer to Table OSM1 for the full wording of each item.**Table OSM3 (continued)**

Item	8	9	10	11	12
8. Very similarly	-				
9. Fails to acknowledge	-.13	-			
10. Unrealistically optimistic	-.32	.61	-		
11. Pressures me	-.05	.31	.45	-	
12. Alienates me	-.29	.59	.71	.41	-
13. Ignores the challenges	-.11	.73	.61	.32	.60

Note. Refer to Table OSM1 for the full wording of each item.

Table OSM4

Condition	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	Lower Confidence Limit	Upper Confidence Limit	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Simple Slopes						
Mindfulness	-0.70	0.69	-2.06	0.67	-1.01	.316
Self-glorification (SG)	2.14	0.73	0.70	3.57	2.93	.004
Facticity	-1.38	0.96	-3.27	0.51	-1.44	.151
Contrasts						
<i>Low Narcissism</i>						
Mindfulness - SG	1.19	0.27	0.55	1.83	4.37	<.001
Mindfulness - Facticity	0.17	0.29	-0.52	0.86	0.58	.831
SG - Facticity	-1.02	0.30	-1.74	-0.30	-3.35	.003
<i>Average Narcissism</i>						
Mindfulness - SG	0.67	0.20	0.20	1.13	3.39	.002
Mindfulness - Facticity	0.30	0.20	-0.17	0.77	1.49	.300
SG - Facticity	-0.37	0.21	-0.86	0.12	-1.78	.180
<i>High Narcissism</i>						
Mindfulness - SG	0.14	0.27	-0.49	0.78	0.54	.854
Mindfulness - Facticity	0.42	0.30	-0.28	1.13	1.41	.336
SG - Facticity	0.28	0.31	-0.44	1.00	0.91	.633

Note. $df=223$; the model for the probes did not include toxic positivity. Low narcissism = -0.184 (-1 *SD*), average narcissism = 0 (mean-centered), and high narcissism = 0.184 (+1 *SD*).